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Rebuilding the village

In 1947, men were few in the village, and there were more women than men. Almost all the men were working in the cities, and the village was silent. There were few activities, and, actually, it was dead. Sometimes in the winter we would gather at Kamel's home in the afternoon to entertain ourselves. In summer we usually sat on the sand next to Salah Kolo's house. Kolo was popular and a wonderful entertainer. He could recount tales and stories, and everyone used to sit and listen to him for hours at a time.

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When Kamel found it impossible to continue earning his living here and had to leave the village, we moved the gatherings to my house. I leveled the ground in front of my house and put new sand to make it soft. But in 1950 the association bought a portable radio, and Sheikh Muhammad kept it in the guest room of his house. I don't know why he had a right to do that, but people began to move there in the evenings and listen to the radio on his *mastaba*.

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Ten years ago there was a large group of worshipers in the mosque every evening. Hag Abdullah was always the first man there, but many people went for the evening lesson and prayer. This was mainly due to the great number of old men who were alive in the village at that time. Now the young men are too lazy to go to the mosque, and they prefer to pray at Sheikh Muhammad's *mastaba* where they can entertain each other and joke and gossip until they are ready to sleep.

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When I came to the village, Hag Abdullah and Ali Amin had the responsibility for distribution of the government rations, that is, flour and oil, among the villagers. At that time Sheikh Muhammad did not have his store, but Ali Amin had one as well as Hag Abdullah. The people in the village became dissatisfied with the way these men distributed the food. It was found that they raised prices. Everyone became angry and acted against them. A large meeting was held, and Ahmed Ali, who was living in the village at that time, suggested that distribution of the rations be put in the hands of Sheikh Muhammad. Everyone approved, and so it was given to him in a peaceful way. At that time the ration was sugar, oil, tea, and cloth. Now it is only sugar and oil. Sheikh Muhammad opened his store in 1951. This was about the time that he took over distribution of the rations from the government. Since he was janitor of the school, he registered the store in the name of Mahmoud, his son. For some time now, I have been  136 wanting to advise him to change the license to some other name because his son is now employed outside the village, but I am hesitating. I am afraid that he would be angry, and if anyone reported him to the government he might think it was me.

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